

"So no one's guilty for the exam paper leak. How did they leak from a locked vault? Was it some magician's trick?"

SACHIN PILOT
Former Dy CM, Rajasthan

books of the anti-Raje lobby in the BJP, in the state and at the Centre. Even if one discounts Gehlot's allegations against Pilot, it's true that the saffron party's legal moves in the tussle between the two have helped the latter. In 2020, it was the lawyers known to be close to the BJP who challenged Speaker C.P. Joshi's notice to Pilot amid his revolt on why his membership and that of his cohort MLAs should not be terminated for boycotting the Congress legislature party meeting. Now, it's BJP deputy leader of the opposition Rajendra Rathore who has gone to the Rajasthan High Court to challenge the Speaker's delay in deciding on the resignation letters of 91 MLAs dating from the Gehlot camp's September revolt. State BJP leaders also keep backing Pilot publicly, and keep inviting him to join their party.

"Pilot's personality does enthuse voters but we do not want him to get sucked into Gehlot's ploy of getting him to quit the Congress. He has a long way to go," says a veteran leader close to Pilot. Sources say the Rajasthan Congress in-charge, former Punjab deputy CM Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, is at his wit's end. He reportedly asked once, 'Tell me, how can we win with Gehlot and Pilot around?" The CM has been accompanying Randhawa on his tours to judge the popular response to his policies, such as universal health coverage. The initial assessment is that anti-incumbency is low though people are angry with some MLAs, says a Gehlot aide.

Party insiders say Gehlot has responded to the high command over Pilot's accusations. "Pilot's revolt has adversely affected governance. Officials keep wondering if my government will last and those who helped save our government want favours in return. I feel anguished at the damage his revolt has caused," the CM told reporters recently He firmly believes he will be leading the party in the election. What he needs now is a great last budget to bolster his case. As for Pilot, perhaps he could work out a strategy that doesn't rely on outright dissent. If the Congress loses, both leaders will have a lot to answer for. ■

KARNATAKA

WOOING THE WOMEN

By Ajay Sukumaran

With the assembly election in Karnataka due before May this year, women voters in the state suddenly find themselves becoming the prime focus for the two key parties in the state, the Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). On January 16, Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, speaking at the party's Naa Nayaki convention in Bengaluru, promised that under its proposed Gruha Lakshmi scheme, it would give Rs 2,000 to female heads of families if voted to power. The ruling BJP, losing no time either, published—on the same day—front-page newspaper advertisements about its own Grihini Shakti scheme, which would provide financial assistance of a similar amount to housewives from low-income families. The race seems to have only begun.

At the Naa Nayaki convention, Priyanka said that the Congress is working on a separate manifesto for women, just like it had done in Uttar Pradesh in 2021. "When we first made a women's manifesto in UP, many people laughed at us," she recalled. And it's true. That attempt in UP had proved to be a damp squib—the Congress ended up being reduced to just two seats in the state. But the step, according to Priyanka, did bring about a crucial shift in that it made political parties take note of women voters. Thus, in last year's Himachal Pradesh